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CHAPTER

65 Expanded United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL II)

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Abstract

This chapter focuses on the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL), a peacekeeping mission created by the UN Security Council in August 2006 to monitor the cessation of hostilities on the Israeli-Lebanese border. After providing a background on the conflict between Israel and Lebanon and the temporary involvement of European nations such as France and Italy in the UN peacekeeping efforts, the chapter outlines UNIFIL's mandate and evaluates its operational achievements and limitations. It also discusses the challenges that UNIFIL had to deal with, including the Hezbollah and a local population suspicious of its real objectives. Finally, it considers the lessons that can be learned from UNIFIL's experience.

Keywords: [UNIFIL](#), [peacekeeping mission](#), [UN Security Council](#), [Israel](#), [Lebanon](#), [France](#), [Italy](#), [Hezbollah](#), [United Nations](#)

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Introduction

AFTER the completion of the withdrawal of the Israeli army from southern Lebanon in 2000, the UN Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL, see chapter 18) slowly reduced its imprint. In the implementation of its mandate, it also had to deal with a new powerful organization: the Hezbollah. The third pillar of UNIFIL's mandate (the recovering of Lebanese authority south of the Litani river) remained to be implemented. Until early 2006, the situation in the area was relatively calm despite minor violations along the Blue Line with occasional breaches of the ceasefire creating continuous tensions between the parties. The mission also continued to provide humanitarian assistance to the local population.

Against this backdrop, after months of tension, new hostilities on the Israeli-Lebanese border began on 12 July 2006 when Hezbollah militants entered Israel capturing two soldiers and killing three others. Israel's response was fierce: it imposed a maritime blockade, bombed Beirut's airport, Lebanese harbors and key roads, hit the country's infrastructure, pounded Hezbollah's strongholds in southern Lebanon, the Bekaa Valley, and south Beirut, killing approximately 400 civilians and forcing the displacement of more than half a million others.¹ The Israeli Defense Forces (IDF) destroyed numerous roads and bridges in southern Lebanon, within and outside the UNIFIL area of operations. Hezbollah attacked IDF positions and Israeli towns south of the Blue Line.

The UN Security Council was involved with this latest phase of the Lebanon war from the outset. On 13 July 2006, the day after the start of the Israeli Operation over Lebanon (Operation "Change of Direction"), the Council met and discussed a draft resolution on the Middle East presented by Qatar to "condemn all acts of violence, terror and destruction" and to "call for Israeli soldiers' release." It was vetoed by the United States.²

p. 768 The Council met again on 14 July, but could not issue any presidential or press statement. Throughout the first fifteen days of the crisis, the Council was hamstrung by American obstructionism. By contrast, Secretary-General Kofi Annan seized on the need for an immediate ceasefire, and made this the centerpiece for his diplomacy during the early phase of the crisis.

The new hostilities radically changed the context in which UNIFIL operated. The Force continued to occupy all of its positions. Despite being severely impeded by ongoing violence, UNIFIL peacekeepers maintained military observation, assisted in humanitarian efforts, and provided medical assistance, all at great risk. The intense fighting in July and August injured sixteen UN staff, and caused the death of five.³

After lengthy negotiations, the Security Council unanimously adopted, on 11 August 2006, Resolution 1701 that sought to end the 30-day conflict. This was the result of an indirect negotiation between Israel and Lebanon (and inside Lebanon, between the government of Fouad Siniora and the Hezbollah), facilitated by the United States and France. It called for a full cessation of hostilities based upon, in particular, "the immediate cessation by Hezbollah of all attacks and the immediate cessation by Israel of all offensive military operations" in Lebanon, and called on the two countries to support a permanent ceasefire and a comprehensive solution to the crisis. The cessation of hostilities was effective on 14 August. Resolution 1701 significantly enhanced UNIFIL from about 2,000 troops just before the war to an authorized level of 15,000 military personnel, and expanded its original mandate. For the first time, the Council also decided to include a Maritime Task Force as part of a UN peacekeeping operation.

Following the cessation of hostilities, the gradual withdrawal of the IDF forces and deployment of Lebanese Armed Forces (LAF), the first elements of the expanded UNIFIL were deployed with record-breaking speed for a peacekeeping operation of such complexity. Battalions from France, Italy, and Spain arrived in the area of operations by 15 September. The swift and effective deployment of the expanded UNIFIL and the activities that the Force has undertaken since have contributed to preventing a recurrence of hostilities across the Blue Line and have helped to establish a new security environment in southern Lebanon. Since then, UNIFIL's area of

responsibility has remained the most stable quarter in a very unstable region in which any hostile act can have a spillover effect.

Mandate and Key Facts

Operation Mandate: Paragraph 11 of Resolution 1701 (11 August 2006) gives the basic mandate of expanded UNIFIL and complements UNIFIL's initial mandate contained in Resolutions 425 and 426 of 1978. New tasks are to:

- (a) Monitor the cessation of hostilities;
- (b) Accompany and support the Lebanese armed forces as they deploy throughout the South, including along the Blue Line, as Israel withdraws its armed forces from Lebanon as provided in paragraph 2;
- (c) Coordinate its activities related to paragraph 11 (b) with the Government of Lebanon and the Government of Israel;
- (d) Extend its assistance to help ensure humanitarian access to civilian populations and the voluntary and safe return of displaced persons;
- (e) Assist the Lebanese armed forces in taking steps towards the establishment of the area as referred to in paragraph 8 [an area free of any armed personnel, assets and weapons other than those of the GOL and of UNIFIL between the Blue Line and the Litani River];
- (f) Assist the Government of Lebanon, at its request, to implement paragraph 14 [to secure its borders].

Strength: August 2006 (Resolution 1701): 15,000 uniformed personnel; *Minimum:* September 2006: 5,747 uniformed personnel; *Maximum:* January 2009: 12,738 uniformed personnel; as of September 2013: 10,555 uniformed personnel; 977 civilian personnel (327 international civilians, 650 local civilians)

Personnel: as of 31 December 2006: Italy (2,415), France (1,617), Spain (1,277), Germany (903), India (878), Indonesia (850), Ghana (660), Belgium (375), Poland (319)

as of 31 September 2013: Indonesia (1,288), Italy (1,137), India (896), Nepal (869), Malaysia (829), Ghana (869), France (863), Spain (587), Ireland (358), Republic of Korea (321), Bangladesh (326), China (343), Brazil (260), Turkey (190).

Finance: 2013–2014: US\$492,622,000

Course of the operation

The context of Resolution 1701⁴

During the 2006 conflict, planning undertaken by all main stakeholders was primarily focused on the deployment of a multinational force led by a coalition of states to stabilize the situation and replace UNIFIL.⁵ However, this idea faded as negotiations in the Security Council were drawing to a close. In the last round of negotiations on the resolution, all sides shifted towards strengthening UNIFIL.

p. 770

For the Israelis, keeping UNIFIL in place became acceptable if the mission was genuinely and sufficiently strengthened: a simple observation mandate was unacceptable. The most important issue for Israel was to have a reinforced security presence on its northern border. The Americans progressively abandoned the idea of having a disarmament component in the mandate, and pushed the Israeli authorities to drop any demand that a UN force would be involved in peace enforcement. For the Lebanese, a UN force was the most politically acceptable type of operation, which led the French also to accept that option. The Lebanese Government insisted on not having Chapter VII of the Charter mentioned, perceiving such a reference as enabling UNIFIL to have enforcement powers. Kofi Annan reassured the Israeli and the Americans that UNIFIL could be a robust force without the explicit mention of Chapter VII. Under-Secretary-General Jean-Marie Guéhenno, head of the Department of Peacekeeping Operations (DPKO), suggested that the draft resolution include provisions for the use of force as a way to reassure existing and future troop contributing countries (TCCs) to UNIFIL. The Siniora Government in the last minutes of the negotiations accepted this paragraph, without having the time to consult with Hezbollah in advance. Russia and China were of the view that any military force would need to be authorized by the Security Council, be agreed by the Lebanese government, and not interfere in internal Lebanese affairs. Russia and China were very important as the French and the Americans increasingly felt that a resolution approved with their abstention would be unacceptable. Overall, the non-permanent members of the Council were pushed into the background on the issue.

The ambiguities of a political mandate

Resolution 1701 has two parts: one that deals with the principles and elements allowing “a permanent ceasefire and a long-term solution” (paragraph 8); and one that “decides ... an increase in the force strength of UNIFIL to a maximum of 15,000 troops” (paragraphs 11 and 12). Therefore, the elements of the peace process that remain to be negotiated (such as the “full implementation of the relevant provisions of the Taif Accords, and of Resolution 1559,” the absence of “foreign forces in Lebanon without the consent of its Government,” the absence of “sales or supply of arms and related material to Lebanon except as authorized by its Government”) are not part of UNIFIL’s mandate. In that respect, the task of the UN force only helps in defusing tensions and encouraging the parties to fully “respect the Blue Line,” to be part of the “security arrangements” needed “to prevent the resumption of hostilities” (which led to the creation of a tripartite mechanism between UNIFIL, IDF, and LAF), and to remove landmines.

It is worth pointing out that the political process (sketched out in paragraph 8 of Resolution 1701) had not been agreed by the parties to the conflict prior to the deployment of the UN operation; they are elements that the members of the Security Council consider useful in order to stabilize Lebanon politically.⁶ By delineating the Blue Line, UNIFIL contributes to improving the stability in its area of responsibility (AOR) now extended to the “pocket of Tyre.” Any threat to “the territorial integrity, sovereignty and political independence of Lebanon within its internationally recognized borders” would therefore constitute a breach of Resolution 1701.

p. 771

Paragraph 11 complements UNIFIL’s initial mandate contained in Resolutions 425 and 426 of 1978 (see chapter 18). It does not authorize any active disarmament of Hezbollah or of other militias. Paragraph 12 gives the strengthened UNIFIL the power to carry out its mandate, by authorizing it “to take all necessary action in areas of deployment of its forces and as it deems within its capabilities.”⁷ UNIFIL is therefore clearly authorized to use force despite the absence of an explicit Chapter VII mandate. Its mandate is “to assist [the Government of Lebanon] to exercise its authority throughout the territory,” not to act as its substitute. In a strict interpretation of paragraph 12, this authorization is valid *only* “to ensure that its area of operations is not utilized for hostile activities of any kind, to resist attempts by forceful means to prevent it from discharging its duties under the mandate of the Security Council, ... and to protect civilians under imminent threat of physical violence.”

Temporary involvement of European contributors

Resolution 1701 was an opportunity to give UNIFIL a different posture which would be more credible and effective as a deterrent than previously. However, for European countries that had “left” UN peacekeeping fifteen years before (with the notable exception of UNIFIL as of 1978, see chapter 18), deploying their forces under UN command was a source of major concern.⁸ The UN Secretariat turned to France to provide a major contribution (following its activism in the negotiating process) and to be the backbone of the expanded UNIFIL, or UNIFIL II. The French authorities were hesitant, owing to France’s links with Lebanon, its past policies and its role in the establishment of an International Tribunal for the assassination of Rafic Hariri, as well as its role in the negotiating process over Iranian nuclear capacity.⁹ France also did not want its soldiers to be over-exposed or easy targets. Initially, this led France to be very cautious in announcing the number of troops it would contribute. It also wanted time to put forward conditions for a clear chain of command and means for force protection. It agreed to keep the Force Commander, General Alain Pellegrini in post for another six months to allow a smooth transition between the two formats before handing over the leadership to an Italian officer. On 24 August 2006, French President Jacques Chirac announced the deployment of 2,000 troops for UNIFIL II “after having secured the conditions for a safe and efficient operation.”¹⁰ During these 15 days of “hesitation” France showed that it did not want to have the lead of UNIFIL II, but that it wished to share the burden with other EU member states.

Other European nations took differing approaches to deployment. Italy was the most assertive, with Prime Minister Romano Prodi giving his commanders in the theatre of operations a relatively free hand to ensure that they had a high-profile role in the new force. Italy announced the deployment of 2,000 to 3,000 troops and its intention to hold the position of Force Commander.¹¹ However, senior Italian officers shared their French counterparts’ desire to place conditions on their deployment. Spain became the third main European contributor, taking its place in the command structure. Germany found itself in an unusual situation as it wished to engage in the operation but did not want to put any ground troops in a position where they might conceivably confront the IDF. Berlin therefore decided to focus its contribution in the new “Maritime Task Force” off Lebanon to persuade Israel to drop its blockade of the Lebanese coast and—at least in theory—restrict the flow of arms to Hezbollah by sea.¹² By December 2006, Europeans were providing 70 percent of the Force’s strength.¹³

p. 772 The slow return to “business as usual”

After the first few months of deployment, UNIFIL had to adjust itself to a tense situation where the local population was suspicious of its real objectives.¹⁴ Even if the parties to the conflict had given their consent to the strengthening of UNIFIL, some did not easily accept its new *modus operandi*, patrolling in all the corners of the AOR. Furthermore, both parties decided to test the resolve and the deterrence of the enhanced UNIFIL. Israel continued its overflights by jets and unmanned aerial vehicles, and saw that none of them were targeted by the capabilities deployed by UNIFIL. Hezbollah watched UNIFIL closely and used the population to prevent it from searching villages where weapons could be hidden and from collecting information on explosions of arms depots.¹⁵ Blue Helmets had to face constant harassment from civilians throwing stones at them, stealing their equipment and restraining their movements. In June 2007 a bomb exploded, killing six Spanish peacekeepers.¹⁶ These challenges led UNIFIL to adopt a more low-key approach “by moving away from overt peace enforcement type activities towards, ironically, a more UNIFIL I-style grassroots focus.”¹⁷ Clearly, both sides wanted to prove that UNIFIL’s robustness had limits. For the sake of gaining the support of the local population and avoiding unnecessary escalation, UNIFIL could not allow itself to be confrontational with either of the parties. Despite its resources, “UNIFIL is in no position to stop the IDF in case of a new invasion. Similarly, if Hezbollah forces are able to resist IDF, they will not be stopped by the use of force by UN peacekeepers with fewer capabilities and even less political incentive to do so.”¹⁸ These hesitations showed UNIFIL’s weakness in a region where any tactical move can have strategic consequences.

UNIFIL's deterrence capacity therefore degraded slowly, and it turned into an observation force that keeps its area of operations immune from recurrent Lebanese political turmoil and regional instability. The only deterrent factor that remained within UNIFIL was the contribution of European states, but even this gradually declined, with European countries representing only 30 percent of the total strength of the Force in 2014. Furthermore, the differences between the separate national contingents in their approach to problems, "as a result of differences in national interests, political outlooks, military doctrines, linguistic ability and equipment," have challenged the unity of the Force.¹⁹ Therefore, after a few months of stabilization of the security situation, the Force found itself in a new stalemate with no clear final objective, a situation that most European contingents were not used to.

Achievements and limitations

Peaceful area of responsibility and cooperation of the parties

p. 773 The February 2013 report of the Secretary-General on UNIFIL underlined "the unprecedented calm that has continued to prevail across the Blue Line between Lebanon and Israel since 2006."²⁰ This is indeed the main achievement of UNIFIL since the cessation of hostilities brought about by Resolution 1701. This has been made possible through a three-dimensional presence of UNIFIL: as a security buffer, as a mechanism for de-escalation, and as an important actor in the local economy.²¹ This has been achieved by the impressive size of the force (more than 10,000 soldiers in a relatively small territory) and its new *modus operandi*. Between 1978 and 2006 UNIFIL had a static posture, occupying a series of observation posts along the Blue Line. Since 2006 UNIFIL has established over sixty positions, checkpoints, and observation posts throughout the AOR, and it conducts about 10,000 vehicle, foot, and air patrols over any 24-hour period, 10 percent of them being done jointly with the LAF. So far, on the Blue Line, "the number of points agreed between the parties for marking stood at 257 of a total of 473."²²

This has been helped by the renewed interest of all parties to have UNIFIL stabilize the situation, as long as it does not cross the "red lines" of Resolution 1701 (in particular the issue of disarmament of militias). This constituted the major change from the former UNIFIL: the enhanced UNIFIL is working in support of a local actor, the LAF. On 27 December 2008, for the first time since the establishment of the force, the President of Lebanon, Michel Sleiman, visited UNIFIL headquarters. However, this partner has become increasingly weak, in particular due to the instability north of the Litani river where LAF had to deploy more and more troops. It is worth pointing out that for a long time, Israel also had an interest in keeping the LAF weak as its composition (in the majority Shi'ites) is perceived as a source of concern.²³ This weakness prevents UNIFIL from handing over to the local authorities. Hezbollah has also accepted the presence of UNIFIL, which had to increasingly rely on its protection and information (especially, when the threats are coming from the extremist Sunni militias present in the Palestinian camps of the area).

This stability has also been achieved through the cooperation of UNIFIL with the parties in coordination mechanisms and regular tripartite meetings. The Secretary-General considers these as "an essential confidence-building mechanism between the parties," and they are in fact the only setting where the Lebanese and Israeli military have a forum for direct exchange.²⁴ UNIFIL is thus able to defuse tensions and prevent incidents along the Blue Line by holding regular tripartite meetings with senior representatives of the LAF and the IDF, in which all critical security issues are addressed. When necessary, UNIFIL interposed itself between LAF and IDF soldiers, seeking to reduce tensions.²⁵ A "hotline" was also established between the UNIFIL Force Commander and the IDF to report Blue Line violations and any other emergency issues that may arise, while a similar mechanism was established with the LAF, both in Tyre and in the Defense Ministry headquarters.²⁶

p. 774

In 2013, Israel and Lebanon both oppose any downsizing of UNIFIL, let alone its departure. For the Israelis, UNIFIL constitutes a useful buffer zone on its Northern border, a tool that can curtail the freedom of movement of Hezbollah and other armed groups, and is a way to keep the European contributors engaged in the region. For the Lebanese, UNIFIL is a security recourse while their army deploys to hotter spots in the country. Finally, UNIFIL also has an impact on the local economy and on the job market in Southern Lebanon, the local population being therefore reluctant to its downsizing ↵ or withdrawal. It also contributes to the safety/cleaning-up of the area by helping to remove unexploded ordnances and ensures continuous humanitarian assistance to the local population.

UNIFIL's command structures

Having still in mind the failures of UN peacekeeping of the mid-1990s, and notwithstanding the French presence in UNIFIL I, the French military establishment put certain conditions to the deployment of its soldiers under UN command: robust rules of engagement that “must guarantee the freedom of movement of the Force and its capacity for action,” means for the protection of the force (that led to the deployment of Leclerc Main Battle Tanks and Short Range Air Defense), a clear (that is “simple, coherent and reactive”) military chain of command with the establishment of a dedicated cell for UNIFIL at UN Headquarters in New York.²⁷

The establishment of this dedicated cell—called “Strategic Military Cell” (SMC)—was the most notable development in the expanded UNIFIL. Initially, the purpose of the SMC was to become UNIFIL's Operations Headquarters, at the strategic level of command and decision. The second idea was to have a permanent direct link with New York for the Force in Naqoura in case of a crisis, allowing the Force Commander to talk directly to the “Operations Commander” (the Chief of that SMC). The French military establishment therefore conceived a small military structure built on the “J Structure” of military headquarters, composed of representatives of TCCs (and representatives of the permanent members of the Security Council) and commanded by a 3-Star General with a direct link to the political level in New York (the Secretary-General or the head of DPKO). This structure could be placed within or (preferably, in their view) outside DPKO.

p. 775

The establishment of this structure had to be negotiated with the UN Secretariat, the objective of Jean-Marie Guéhenno being to create it inside DPKO, under his direct command and control. The head of the SMC thus became a “director” instead of a “commander.” The SMC was included in the structure of DPKO but outside its Military Division and its Office of Operations, which therefore perceived it as an intruder that would be included into the daily work with great reluctance.²⁸ The SMC's Director was a member of DPKO's senior management team and part of the Lebanon Working Group chaired by the Director of the Asia and Middle East Division. He had no stronger voice than any other DPKO director except on military affairs (where the head of DPKO was also guided by the views of the Force Commander and of DPKO's Military Advisor). Even the Force Commander did not always use that structure, often seeing it as a buffer between him and the Under Secretary-General. More generally, the SMC was also perceived as the result of Western whim that forced the UN to establish a dedicated cell of 33 persons for a peacekeeping operation in which they were engaged as the Military Division had only 43 persons to do the planning and monitoring for 17 or 18 parallel operations. Politically, the Non-Aligned Movement therefore ↵ severely criticized it, within the framework of the Special Committee on Peacekeeping Operations of the General Assembly in particular. Yet the UN Secretariat understood that such a structure was the condition for the contribution of European nations to UNIFIL, and even acknowledged its usefulness.²⁹ It eventually led in 2007 to the transformation of the Military Division into an Office of Military Affairs, in which the SMC was dissolved in 2010.³⁰

The second peculiarity of UNIFIL's command and control structure is the fact that it does not have a Special Representative of the Secretary-General (SRSG) as Head of Mission but a Force Commander. The strategic changes of 2006 could have been an opportunity for DPKO to put UNIFIL command and control structures more in line with other UN operations of the post-Cold War era. Yet the French military were determined to

avoid the system in place at the time of UNPROFOR in Bosnia and Herzegovina. France therefore rejected the appointment of an SRSG; instead the UN created in February 2007 the position of Special Coordinator for Lebanon (to be head of a political mission of about twenty internationals, reporting to the UN Department of Political Affairs), located in Beirut, in charge of all political aspects of the operation.³¹ The 2012 Strategic Review undertaken by DPKO acknowledged the fact that the political aspects of UNIFIL needed to be strengthened: a civilian Deputy Head of Mission was thus appointed “in order to strengthen and institutionalize the relationship between the political and the military leadership of UNIFIL.” It also recommended a better synergy between UNIFIL and the UN Special Coordinator Office in Lebanon (UNSCOL) through “the establishment of a formalized consultative Process.”³²

The limits of a military mandate in the absence of a credible exit strategy

UNIFIL was strengthened in the summer of 2006 to the extent that was diplomatically feasible in the Security Council and acceptable to the parties. Resolution 1701 did not create a new peacekeeping operation in Southern Lebanon; rather it strengthened an existing one by trying to build on a new momentum. However, despite a few differences, this enhanced UNIFIL faced the same limitations as the “old one.” The new mission remained a “traditional” blue helmet operation, a form increasingly untypical of other current UN missions. As such, it is an almost purely military affair led by its Force Commander, whereas most other UN operations are multidimensional, with a strong civilian component and a civilian SRSG.

But contrary to its previous incarnation, the strengthened UNIFIL has been accepted by both principal parties to the conflict, although for very different reasons. This situation reflects the fact that the Security Council’s members were not ready to invest in solutions to regional tensions beyond the immediate 2006 war. This is also the reason why since then the mandate has been renewed each year as Council members seem reluctant to p. 776 reopen the substance of the original provisions of Resolution 1701. In the end, the ↪ mission was restructured to satisfy the immediate political and diplomatic conditions of 2006, but not to support longer-term progress towards peace. Indeed, “UNIFIL II may persist as an indefinite “interim” mission, especially given that the UN Security Council, the EU, and the US continue to neglect the larger political framework needed to resolve the outstanding conflict.”³³ The 2012 UNIFIL Strategic Review acknowledged the fact that “UNIFIL does not have the mandate or the tools to tackle the root causes of the conflict, which remain largely unaddressed.”³⁴ A resolution that cannot evolve will contribute to the freezing of the operation and prevent the elaboration of any credible exit strategy or realistic final status. Also, “an operation with a limited political mandate can only achieve limited objectives. In that sense, the enhanced UNIFIL cannot be strategically decisive: it manages conflict on an interim basis, but does not make peace.”³⁵

Conclusion

One can ask whether UNIFIL II is very much different from UNIFIL I. The enhanced UNIFIL was able to contribute to the new strategic environment created by the LAF deployment in the South and by the renewed contribution of European states. But it faces the same political limitations. Resolution 1701 merely strengthened an existing peacekeeping force. As such, UNIFIL like other peacekeeping operations evolved according to certain rules and principles and has proved to be unable to engage in effective peace enforcement. As the first Secretary-General's report in reference to Resolution 1701 explained: "A reinforced UNIFIL is not going to wage war on any of the actors in the theatre. It is not expected to achieve by force what must be realized through negotiation and an internal Lebanese consensus." It added: "Nor can a reinforced UNIFIL be a substitute for a political process. That political process, however, will need the kind of help, assistance and confidence that only a robust peacekeeping presence can provide, in support of the Government of Lebanon and its efforts to exercise its authority effectively throughout its territory."³⁶ In other words, the robust posture of the expanded UNIFIL is only a means to create a security environment conducive to the implementation of a permanent ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon (paragraph 8 of Resolution 1701).

The fact that UNIFIL is not supported by any effective political process, in 2014 as much as in 2006 or in 1978, constitutes the fundamental flaw of the operation. In this situation the most determined contributors would not be able to achieve anything else than purely military objectives. In a situation where a peacekeeping operation is deployed as a substitute for a political process, military robustness is unlikely to produce any substantive result. As the DPKO pointed out in a 2011 internal note, robustness is about being both: politically and militarily robust.³⁷ In this sense, the strengthening of UNIFIL created an illusion about the capabilities of the Force, as well as about the will and cohesion of its contributors. In such circumstances, deterrence could only wither over time. Similarly, UNIFIL will have a limited impact if the parties do not have an interest in keeping the area stable or if they are caught up in broader regional turmoil. ↪ As Richard Gowan pointed out, "if any one of a number of players—Hezbollah, Israel, anti-Assad forces in Syria or opponents of Hezbollah inside Lebanon—decides to escalate, the UN can do relatively little to stop them. UNIFIL has weathered major storms in the past 35 years, and even if the situation in Lebanon deteriorates, the mission may still be there to pick up the pieces afterward."³⁸

p. 777

Notes

1. International Crisis Group, "Israel/Palestine/Lebanon: Climbing out of the Abyss," Middle East Report, no. 57, 25 July 2006.
2. Meeting of the Security Council (S/PV.5488) where the draft resolution was vetoed (S/2006/508).
3. In particular, in Khiam, on 25 July, four military observers died in an Israeli attack; see www.un.org/News/Press/docs/2006/sgsm10666.doc.htm
4. This section is based on a series of interviews of UN, French, and US officials, between November 2009 and June 2010.
5. On the details of the planning, see Richard Gowan and Alexandra Novosseloff, "Le renforcement de la Force intérimaire des Nations Unies au Liban: Etude des processus décisionnels au sommet," *Annuaire français de relations internationales* XI (2010), 245–267.
6. Interview with a French official, 2010.
7. The wording used for this paragraph is almost entirely copied from the provisions laid down in the Secretary-General report in 1978, thus underlining the continuity between the two forces.
8. The fact was that the military establishment had planned until the very last moment for a force that would be outside the UN institutional framework. A week after the vote of 1701, the French Defense Minister, Michèle Alliot-Marie was still

talking about the possible deployment of a French “rapid reaction force” in support of UNIFIL. Philippe Boloignon, “La France réticente à engager son armée au Liban,” *Le Monde*, 17 August 2006.

9. Interview with a French official, 2010.
10. Laurent Zecchini, “2 000 soldats français participeront à la Finul,” *Le Monde*, 26 August 2006.
11. Philippe Boloignon and Jean-Jacques Bozonnet, “L’Italie propose de prendre les rênes de la force internationale,” *Le Monde*, 23 August 2006.
12. Initially of about 1,800 marines, with Germany as a lead nation, the UNIFIL maritime component was progressively downsized to 1,000 marines.
13. The rest of the Force was manned by “traditional” African and Asian contributors (Ghana, Nepal, India) and by Muslim troops accepted by Israel (from Turkey and Malaysia).
14. “The arrival of ‘robust’ UNIFIL II units coincided with growing suspicions among most southern Lebanese that these troops were merely tools of a larger US-led initiative to advance Israel’s aims during the war to disarm the Resistance via a peace enforcement operation. Whereas UNIFIL I had, by and large, enjoyed the trust and respect of the local population, the first UNIFIL II troops—particularly those from the Spanish and French contingents—appeared overly militant and disrespectful to the locals.” Karim Makdisi, Timur Göksel, Hans Bastian Hauck, Stuart Reigeluth, “UNIFIL II: Emerging and Evolving European Engagement in Lebanon and the Middle East,” EuroMesco Paper, January 2009, 25.
- p. 778 15. For example in October 2009 (see www.lemonde.fr/proche-orient/article/2009/10/13/depot-d-armes-du-hezbollah-au-liban-israel-porte-plainte-aupres-de-l-onu_1253619_3218.html) or in September 2010 (see www.lepoint.fr/monde/liban-explosion-dans-un-immeuble-dans-le-sud-abritant-un-depot-d-armes-03-09-2010-1232066_24.php).
16. The Fatah al-Islam is alleged to be behind this terrorist act. See Jean-Pierre Perrin, “Cinq Casques bleus espagnols tués au Liban,” *Libération*, 25 June 2007.
17. Makdisi et al., “UNIFIL II,” 25.
18. Alexander Mattelaer, “Europe Rediscovered Peacekeeping? Political and Military Logics in the 2006 UNIFIL Enhancement,” Egmont Paper 34, October 2009, 20.
19. See Makdisi et al., “UNIFIL II,” 20 and 32.
20. S/2013/120, 27 February 2013, para. 75.
21. Mattelaer, “Europe Rediscovered Peacekeeping?,” 7.
22. S/2013/120, 27 February 2013, paras. 15 and 32.
23. Even if that composition only reflects the population balance. LAF is under Maronite command, and the ethnic origins of individual soldiers do not in fact matter much.
24. The aims of the tripartite meetings are also “to enhance liaison and coordination and to address key security and military operational issues, including violations of Resolution 1701 (2006) and the findings of UNIFIL investigations into incidents.” This mechanism is also used to agree on the marking of the Blue Line. See S/2008/425, 27 June 2008, para. 13.
25. S/2010/565, 1 November 2010, para. 18.
26. Makdisi et al., “UNIFIL II,” 25.
27. Quotes from the speech of Jacques Chirac on 24 August, in Laurent Zecchini, *Le Monde*, 26 August 2006.
28. Interview with a UN official, 2010.
29. In his first report the UN Secretary-General describes the creation of the SMC as a necessity for DPKO to provide military guidance rather than as a prerequisite of Member States; see S/2006/670, 18 August 2006, para. 39.
30. A/62/752, 17 March 2008: Report on the comprehensive analysis of the Office of Military Affairs in the Department of

Peacekeeping Operations.

31. Office of the United Nations Special Coordinator for Lebanon (UNSCOL).
32. S/2012/151 (12 March 2012): Letter dated 12 March 2012 from the Secretary-General addressed to the President of the Security Council.
33. S/2012/151, 12 March 2012, 31.
34. S/2012/151 12 March 2012.
35. Mattelaer, "Europe Rediscovered Peacekeeping?" 32.
36. S/2006/670, 18 August 2006, para. 61.
37. See paper reproduced in Jocelyn Coulon and Alexandra Novosseloff, "La paix par la force? Pour une approche réaliste du maintien de la paix 'robuste,' 2011," Montréal, éditions Athéna, 224 pages.
38. Richard Gowan, "Diplomatic Fallout: For U.N. and Europe, a Peacekeeping Crisis in Lebanon," *World Politics Review*, 25 March 2013.